RE-CONTEXTUALISING THE HUMAN BODY AS AN ELECTRONIC PERFORMANCE INTERFACE

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ABSTRACT

An important factor to consider regarding computer based electronic instruments is the de-coupling of the control and feedback of electronic systems in contrast to the traditional instrument/player relationship where the connection is intimate and precise. In exploiting the potential for complex mapping where multiple sonic events can arise from the most minimal of performance gestures, the performer runs the risk of severing the connection between gesture and sonic result. At an extreme, the use of virtual reality systems and the internet has extended the field of performance activity beyond the physical performance space itself. Working within this technological matrix, the traditional conception of the human body as an agent of gesture has come under scrutiny leading some scholars to question the significance of the body in electronic performance. This presentation will advocate a return to the centralisation of the human body in electronic performance drawing on the phenomenological writings of Maurice Merleau-Ponty. Informed in large part by the authors own performance practice, the artist will discuss the benefits of attaching transducers directly onto the performers body. Such configuration allows for the amplification of the inner biological workings of the human organism. Internal body sounds such as heartbeat and breath cycle can then be used as raw compositional material during performance. The author will claim that this approach establishes the material body as a focal point from which additional technology can then be applied. The presentation will conclude by suggesting that the traditional notion of the performer and instrument as being separate entities can no longer be universally assumed and that a re-contextualisation of the 'human body' as an electronic performance interface is worthy of consideration.